I knew that there must be among our allies other countries that shared our concern about the threat to democracy in Latin America, and I believed we should communicate to them our strong convictions regarding the importance of tangible international support for the Contras. Several countries responded and extended help—a case of friendly nations believing we all had a stake in fighting for democracy.

I believed, then and now, that the president has the absolute constitutional right and obligation to share such thoughts and goals with leaders of other nations.

At about the same time, churches and various groups around our country began forming committees with the intention of helping the freedom fighters and refugees from the Sandinistas. They were made up of private citizens worried about the threat of Communism in Latin America and about things they had read in papers concerning the misguided actions of Congress.

I didn’t want anyone in the administration to engage in active solicitation of contributions from these citizens. But, I said, “there has to be a way to help these private citizens who otherwise wouldn’t know how to get help to the Contras or buy the supplies they need; there must be ways we can help or counsel them if somebody says we’ve raised some money and want to help the Contras; somebody ought to be able to tell them what channel to use.” The staff also asked me to thank citizens who had contributed humanitarian assistance to the Contras, and I was happy to do so. But I repeatedly insisted that whatever we did had to be within the law, and I always assumed that my instructions were followed.

While I continued trying to educate the American people and seek their support in persuading Congress to provide badly needed aid to the freedom fighters, dedicated Americans began contributing money and supplies—one